

Picture books

Children's picture books have a long history; from the *Orbis Pictus* in 1658 there have been picture books for children. Babies and young children can enjoy books in which pictures are just as important as words. The illustrations tell stories and help teach concepts such as colours, shapes, and the names of things. Many talented artists now make books for children.

Visible world

Even the earliest books included illustrations. However, the first picture book that was specially designed for children was called *Orbis Pictus*, or *Visible World* (1658), by John Amos Comenius. It used pictures in order to help the translation of German into Latin.



Merchandising

Successful children's books are now big business. Popular characters soon appear as toys, games, and even crockery. The image of the characters can be found printed on clothing and books.

Beatrix Potter

The first master of the picture story book was Beatrix Potter (1866–1943). She was a lonely child who taught herself to draw and became skillful at painting animals. Her first book, *The Tale of Peter Rabbit*, was published in 1901. The books of Beatrix Potter are still popular throughout the world.

Beatrix Potter merchandise

Cuddly Peter Rabbit toy

Teapot

Mug

Beatrix Potter books are printed in many languages.

Jug

Board game

Where the Wild Things Are

When this book was published by the American writer Maurice Sendak (b.1928) in 1963, many people thought it was too scary for children. It tells the story of a boy called Max, who sails away to the land of the Wild Things, where after many adventures, he becomes their king.



Dr Seuss

The American artist Dr Seuss (Theodore Geisel 1904–90) created many classic picture books. Stories such as *The 500 Hats of Bartholomew Cubbins* (1938) are built around strange and improbable situations. Dr Seuss was one of the first authors to make rhyming storybooks that helped teach children to read. In *The Cat in the Hat* (1958), a cat visits two children and creates rhyming chaos while their mother is away.



Children's poetry

Verse for children dates back to the songs and ballads of the oral tradition, and children still memorize rhymes and songs and pass them on among themselves. Children's poetry has been written in every style imaginable, from humorous fantasies and nonsense limericks to powerful social commentary.



Nursery rhymes

Spoken rhymes are found all over the world, and many are ancient. Little Bo Peep is linked to a hide-and-seek game called Bo-Pepe, which is more than 600 years old. Ring A Ring O' Roses describes the symptoms of the plague, which left rose-like marks on its victims.

Limericks

The English artist Edward Lear (1812–88) wrote many nonsense rhymes. His limericks generally involve all sorts of people in very odd situations.

"There was an old man of Whitehaven, who danced a quadrille with a raven."



Prizes

Today, more children's books are being published than ever before. To encourage good writing and illustration, prizes are awarded for the best books. There are awards for everything from teenage fiction to picture books. Some prizes are nominated by children.



Newbery Medal

The American Library Association awards this prize for the year's best children's book. It is named after John Newbery (1713–67), who opened the world's first children's bookshop in 1745.



Carnegie Medal

This prize has been awarded by the British Library Association since 1936. It takes its name from American millionaire Andrew Carnegie (1835–1919), who founded libraries in Britain and the United States.

Timeline

15th century Chapbooks (crime and miracle stories) published. Courtesy books tell children how to behave.

1745 John Newbery sells *Little Goody Two-Shoes* in the first children's bookshop.

Little Goody Two-shoes

1877 English author Anna Sewall publishes *Black Beauty*.



1883 *Pinocchio*, by Italian author Carlo Collodi (1826–1890) published.

1894 *The Jungle Book*, by Rudyard Kipling (1865–1936) published.

1908 Kenneth Grahame (1859–1932) publishes *The Wind in the Willows*.

1922 The first Newbery Medal for children's literature awarded.

1926 *Winnie-the-Pooh*, by AA Milne (1882–1956) published.

1929 *Emil and the Detectives* by German author Eric Kästner (1899–1974) published.

1931 French artist Jean de Brunhoff publishes *The Story of Babar*.

1952 EB White (1899–1985) publishes *Charlotte's Web*.



1968 *The Pigman* by Paul Zindel (b.1936) published.

1975 *Forever*, one of the first books for teenagers, by American author Judy Blume (b.1938) published.

1997 JK Rowling publishes the first book in the *Harry Potter* series.

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